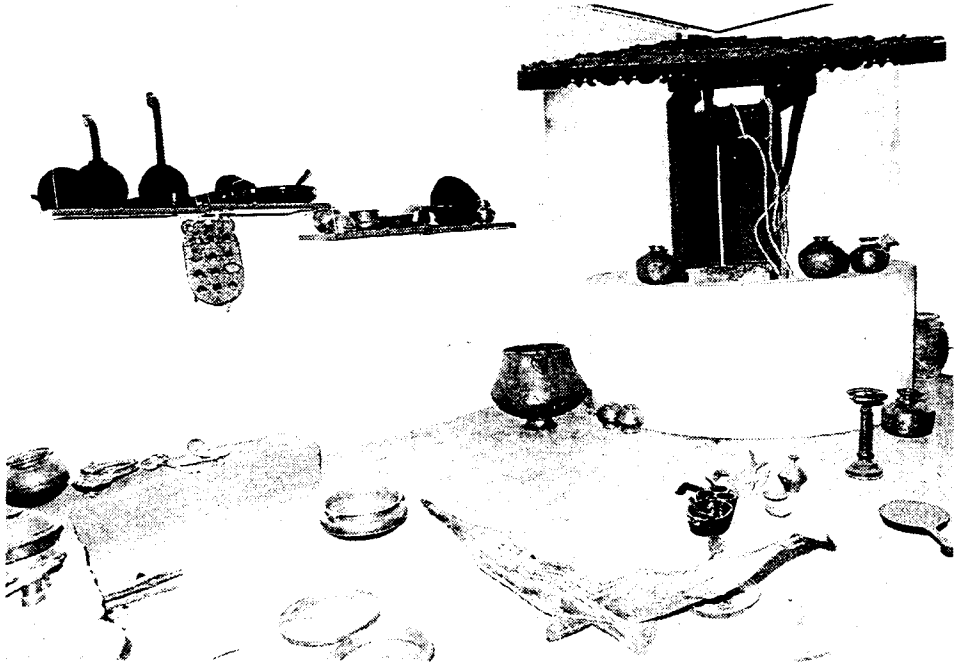
The spirit of Kerala comes alive

Kerala in Madras! Sounds incredible. But that is what it is. On Greames Road. At the Lalit Kala Akademi. The spirit of Kerala comes alive there in a 10-day celebration, made possible by The Madras Craft Foundation, ably aided by INTACH, the Crafts Council of India, Sampradaya, Koothu-p-pattarai and Kerala's Department of Tourism among a host of others.

And their enthusiasm literally opens this land's charm and warmth through "pumukham", the traditional and ornamental entrance to a "taravad", where it seems that life begins, goes by and ends in all its intricate splendour. The model of a women's room in an exhibition at the Akademi is by far the most impressive, suggesting that the fair sex still commands love and respect in a world that is said to be getting increasingly hostile to them. The grand jewellery boxes are so large that each one of them could hold a fortune for generations of women. The rather odd-looking medicine chest to store the secrets of Ayurveda provides another kind of security. The religious book, the knick-knacks for puja and the 13th century Gajalakshmi lamp are tonic for the soul.

The model of the kitchen has a couple of interesting things to show. The well just outside the kitchen window helps a woman to draw water without getting drenched in a climate that is largely wet. The coconut grinders, to be operated by two, the copper and bronze utensils, the pickle jars and the oil cans are so huge that they can but imply prosperity through the ages. The bedroom, with the moonlight peeping shyly through a unique slit window, offers the right atmosphere with a bed that is largely functional, a writing desk and a document box, hung from the ceiling to keep pests off.

There are other things at home, and the exhibition — to be open till Sunday — satisfies the curiosity of a viewer. The mirrors made from metal, whose manufacturing secrets are never allowed to escape the hearts of the last two surviving brothers from Aranmula may not be seen for long. So also the traditional costumes in white and cream with gold borders, modernism having made rapid strides in fashion and outlook. Possibly, it is a matter of time before the likes of the rare 13th century Vinayaki, the exquisite wooden head of a bull and the elaborate Teyyam mask walk out of drawing rooms and into museums, to be peered at more out of a sense of ritual than real interest. More likely, they may end up as photographs: there is a fascinating set at the exhibition that shows the Puli Bhagavathi (Tiger Goddess), "Vishnumurthi" in trance, a scene from Thira (a dance from central Kerala) and the like.



A traditional Kerala kitchen

When one is through with the pictures on the wall, the Celebration offers flesh and blood shows. One of them was the Patayani, a masked march that combined 64 art forms revealing the political, social and cultural faces of ancient Kerala even as it snaked its way from College Road to Greames Road last Sunday. The 11-member troupe of dancers, singers and mask-makers was led by Kadammanitta Ramakrishnan, who popularised poetry recitation back home. Patayani, which traces the battle between Bhadrakali and Darakasura and the efforts of Shiva to calm his consort through an amusing march of birds and horses, is lyrical to be life itself. The troupe's interaction with schoolchildren was useful: the making of masks from betel-nut tree fronds was as time consuming as it was painstaking, and all the more so because they were not used for more than one show.

Kummatti, also performed at the Akademi, is usually a curtain raiser to Onam, the harvest and health. A performer covers himself with leaves and grass and dances to the beat of drum. When he shot the arrow in the midst of cacophonous sounds, it must have pierced the sentiments of many in the crowd. Pavakathakali, the glove puppet art, was almost resurrected from the grave: the little men and women at the finger-tips of larger men did seem to cry out for life, and hope now rests on Natanakairali, an association of traditional artistes, which put up the shows. Kalyana Sougandhikam, Duryodhana Vadham were two of them. A repertoire of Kerala composers presented by Palghat K. V. Narayanaswamy, a Mohiniattam recital by Tara Kalyan and Classical films of Aravindan Adoor Gopalakrishnan, Ravi Varma and others, took you deeper into that land.

Kutiyattam, the Sanskrit theatre form, to which Kathakali owes a lot, may well be one more beautiful feather in the festival cap when it is staged on Friday. Teyyam, with its myths and legends, may not be all that easy to perform at the Akademi on Friday and Saturday. There is apprehension that it may not be right to take it out of the context. Let us leave that to time, and meanwhile, for some appam-avviyal, olan and Payasam, made by the women of the Malayalee Club. — Staff Reporter

The Hindu/18-09-1987/19